Circuit Stage — Competition Format

Men's and Ladies' singles · Circuits 1, 2 and 3 · SportPesa National Pool Circuit 2026/27

DRAFT V1 FOR COMMITTEE REVIEW · 2 NOVEMBER 2026

At a glance

MEN'S FIELD	LADIES' FIELD	ROUND 1	ROUND 2	OUTCOME
128	**55**	**Double**	**Knockout**	**1 + 1**
full bracket, no byes	64 slots, 9 byes	elimination · race to 6	straight · race to 5	champion per category

Each circuit is a self-contained competition. Round 1 is a double-elimination phase that halves the field: a player must lose **twice** to go out. Everyone who survives Round 1 enters Round 2 with a clean sheet, and from there a single loss ends the run — straight knockout down to a champion.

	MEN	LADIES
Entrants	128	55
Bracket slots	128	64
Byes in Round 1	0	9
Eliminated in Round 1	64	23
Qualify for Round 2	64	32
Matches played, Round 1	160	62
Matches played, Round 2	63	31
Total matches per circuit	**223**	**93**

Ladies' Round 1 total excludes 9 byes and 9 losers'-bracket walkovers, which are awarded rather than played.

Round 1 — double elimination, race to 6

Round 1 runs as four waves of matches. The winners' side and the losers' side both play, and the two sides meet once, in the crossover, before the round closes.

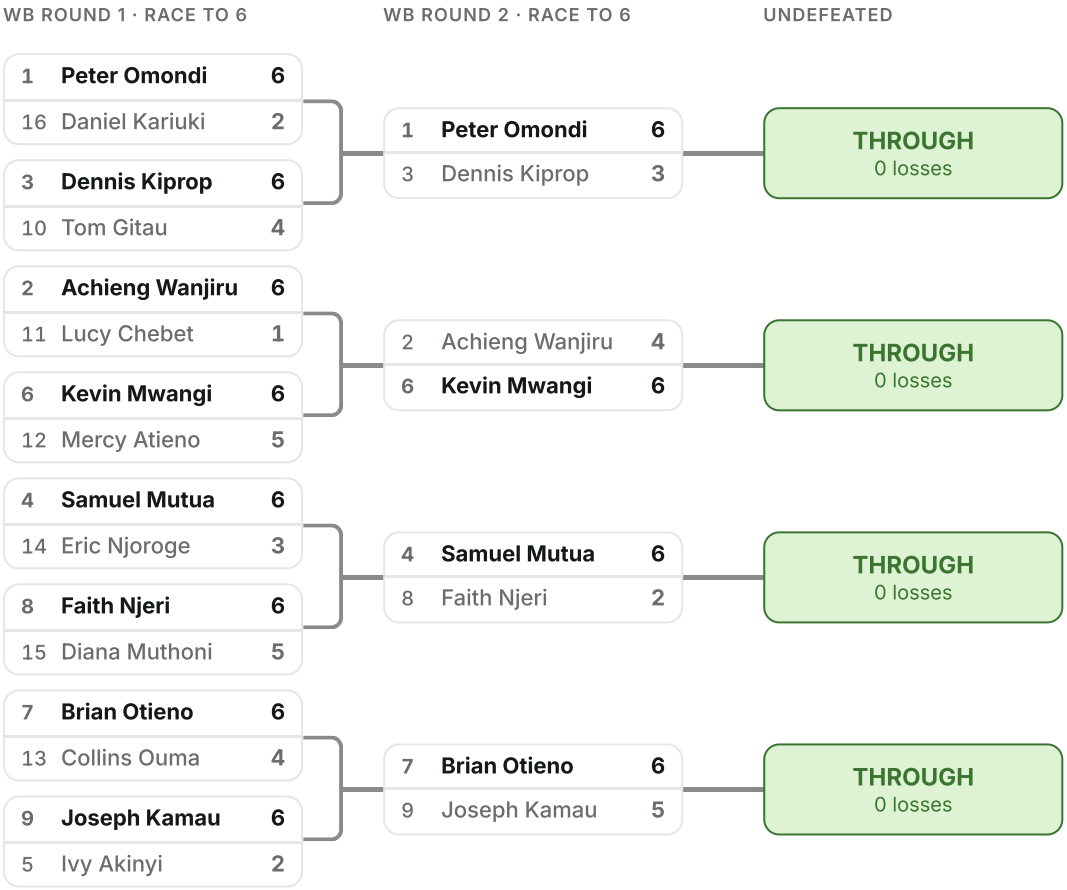
WAVE	WHO PLAYS	PLAYERS	MATCHES	WINNERS GO TO	LOSERS GO TO
WB R1	The whole field	128	64	Winners' bracket R2	Losers' bracket R1
WB R2	The 64 unbeaten	64	32	**Round 2** (undefeated)	Losers' bracket R2
LB R1	The 64 first-round losers	64	32	Losers' bracket R2	Eliminated — 2 losses
LB R2	32 WB R2 losers v 32 LB R1 winners	64	32	**Round 2** (one loss)	Eliminated — 2 losses
Round 1 total			**160**	**64 through, 64 out**	

Every Round 1 match is a **race to 6**. The crossover (LB R2) is the match that makes this a true double elimination: a player who lost their opening match can still reach Round 2 by winning two matches on the losers' side.

Round 1 bracket — the format shown at 16 players

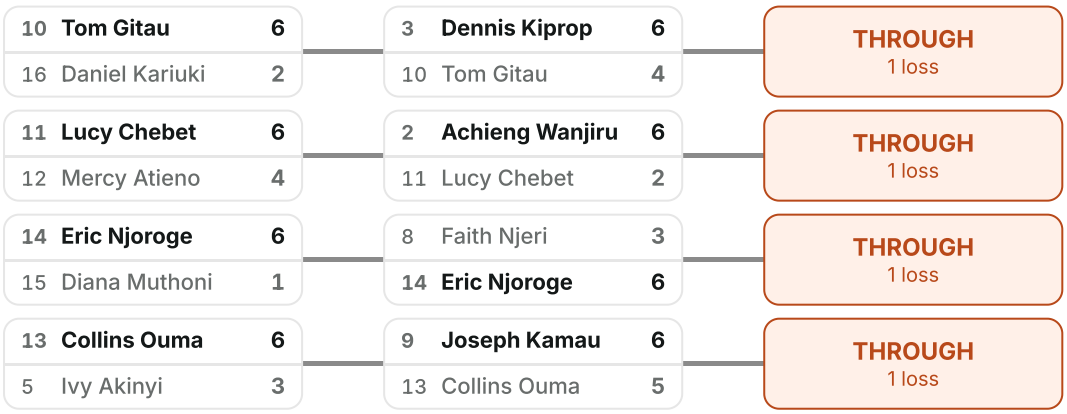
The same bracket as the 128 and 64 draws, scaled down so every match fits on a page: 16 players, 8 through to Round 2. Each card is one match — winner in black, beaten player in grey. The real draws are this shape multiplied.

Winners' side — nobody here has lost



The 8 players beaten in WB Round 1 drop to the losers' side below. The 4 beaten in WB Round 2 drop straight into the crossover.

Losers' side — one more loss and you are out



In each crossover card the top name is the player who has just dropped from WB Round 2 and the bottom name is the LB Round 1 winner. Daniel Kariuki, Mercy Atieno, Diana Muthoni and Ivy Akinyi went out in LB Round 1; Tom Gitau, Lucy Chebet, Faith Njeri and Collins Ouma went out in the crossover — eight players, two losses each.

Round 2 — the 4 undefeated meet the 4 survivors

ROUND 2 · RACE TO 5 · UNDEFEATED V SURVIVOR

1	Peter Omondi
3	Dennis Kiprop

6	Kevin Mwangi
2	Achieng Wanjiru

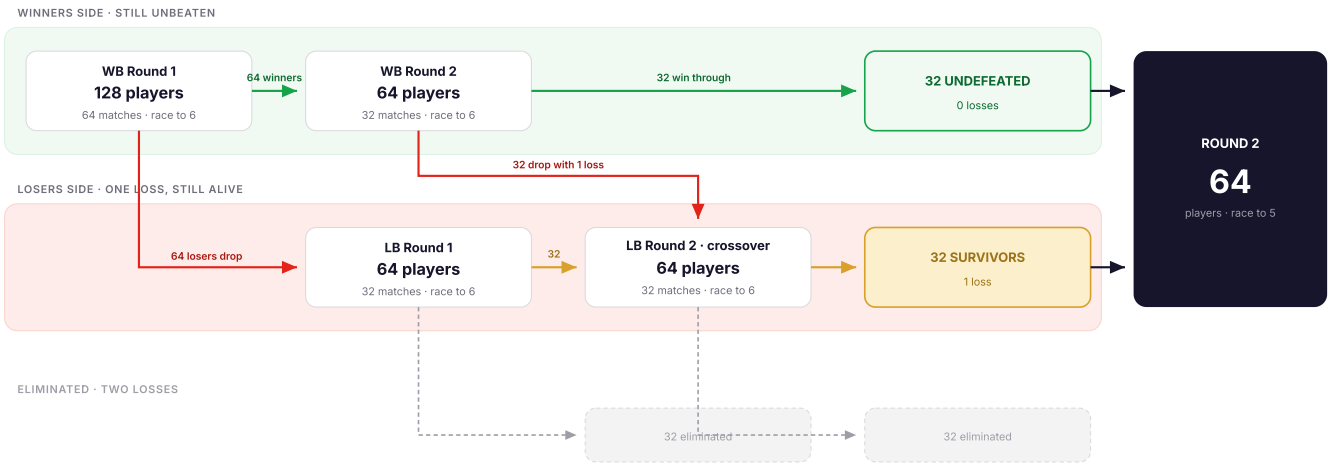
4	Samuel Mutua
14	Eric Njoroge

7	Brian Otieno
9	Joseph Kamau

Dashed cards are not yet drawn. Every opening Round 2 match is undefeated versus survivor, never two undefeated players against each other.

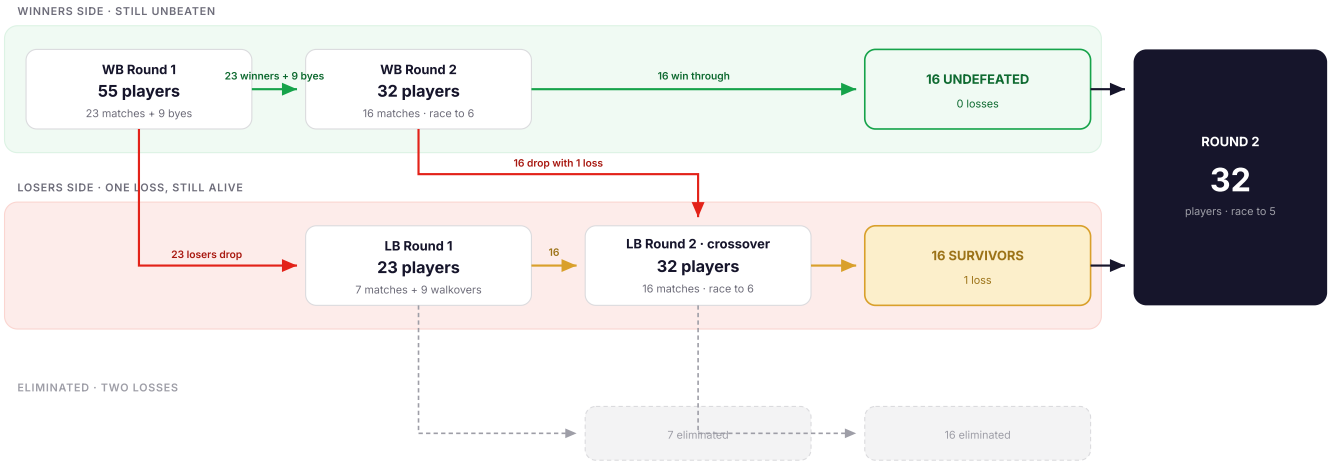
WAVE	SHOWN HERE	MEN'S DRAW	LADIES' DRAW
Field	16	128	55 in 64
WB Round 1 matches	8	64	23 + 9 byes
WB Round 2 matches	4	32	16
LB Round 1 matches	4	32	7 + 9 w/o
Crossover matches	4	32	16
Through to Round 2	**8**	**64**	**32**

Round 1 flow — men's 128 bracket



Green = unbeaten. Amber = alive on one loss. Dashed grey = out on two losses. Each box shows the players entering that wave.

Round 1 flow — ladies' 64 bracket



Same shape, different arithmetic. The 9 byes sit in WB Round 1 and produce no losers, so the losers' side carries 23 players through 32 slots — hence the 9 walkovers in LB Round 1.

The ladies' field: 55 players in a 64 bracket

55 entrants are drawn into a 64-slot bracket, leaving **9 byes**. Byes are assigned by **random draw** among all 55, with one structural constraint described below.

WAVE	PLAYERS IN	PLAYED	AWARDED	ADVANCE	OUT
WB R1	55	23	9 byes	32	0
WB R2	32	16	0	16	0
LB R1	23	7	9 w/o	16	7
LB R2	32	16	0	16	16
Round 1	**55**	**62**	**18**	**32**	**23**

Draw constraint — two byes must never feed the same losers' match

Each losers'-bracket R1 match is fed by the losers of two specific winners'-bracket R1 matches. A bye produces no loser, so it leaves that feeder slot empty. If **both** feeders of one losers' match are byes, that match has no players at all and the losers' side delivers only 15 players into the crossover — which needs exactly 16. The draw must therefore place at most one bye per losers'-bracket pairing. With 9 byes across 16 pairings this is always satisfiable, but it has to be enforced when the draw is made, not checked afterwards.

Why 9 and not some other number

The bye count is whatever brings the field up to the next power of two: 64 − 55 = 9. If entries change at Circuits 2 and 3, the bye count changes with them. Below 33 entrants the bracket should drop to 32 slots rather than carry 30-plus byes.

Round 2 — straight knockout to a champion, race to 5

Round 2 opens with the 32 undefeated players meeting the 32 one-loss survivors. From that point the competition is a conventional single-elimination ladder: lose once and you are out, regardless of how you arrived.



Records from Round 1 do not carry forward — a player who arrives with one loss is on equal footing with an undefeated player. The only advantage of arriving undefeated is in the pairing: the opening Round 2 match is always **undefeated versus one-loss survivor**, never two undefeated players against each other.

STAGE	MEN IN	MATCHES	LADIES IN	MATCHES
Round of 64	64	32	—	—
Round of 32	32	16	32	16
Round of 16	16	8	16	8
Quarter-finals	8	4	8	4
Semi-finals	4	2	4	2
Final	2	1	2	1
Round 2 total	—	**63**	—	**31**

Match volume and session planning

316 matches per circuit across both categories — 223 men's and 93 ladies'. The table below converts that into table-hours. It assumes an average of 45 minutes per match and **no** idle time between matches, so treat it as a floor, not a forecast.

TABLES	TOTAL TABLE-HOURS	HOURS PER DAY OVER 3 DAYS	COMMENT
8	29.6	9.9	Long days; little slack for overruns
10	23.7	7.9	Workable with a disciplined schedule
12	19.8	6.6	Comfortable
16	14.8	4.9	Room for delays and feature-table matches

> **Sequencing constraint**
>
> The waves are strictly ordered: LB R1 cannot start until every WB R1 match is finished, and the crossover needs both WB R2 and LB R1 complete. Those two synchronisation points are where a single slow match holds up the whole room, so they are worth scheduling around.

Confirmed for this draft

- **Round 2 runs to a champion** in each category — the circuit is self-contained.
- **Round 2 is straight knockout**, not a continuation of double elimination.
- **Ladies' byes are drawn at random**, not seeded by ranking or CuevoPoints.
- **The same format applies to all three circuits**; field sizes and bye counts are recalculated per circuit from actual entries.

Open points for the committee

1. **Race lengths get shorter as the stakes rise.** Round 1 is a race to 6 and Round 2 — including quarter-finals, semi-finals and the final — is a race to 5. This is the opposite of the usual pattern. Confirm it is deliberate, or set a longer race for the closing stages.
2. **Third-place playoff.** The two beaten semi-finalists currently finish joint third. Is a playoff wanted, for placings or for prize money?
3. **Round 1 draw rules.** Is the opening draw purely random, or are there restrictions such as keeping players from the same venue or region apart in early matches?
4. **Round 2 re-draw.** Is the undefeated-versus-survivor pairing drawn fresh at the start of Round 2, or fixed by bracket position carried over from Round 1?
5. **How the three circuits combine.** Each circuit produces a champion. What carries forward to the Finals — circuit champions only, accumulated CuevoPoints, or a ranking across all three?
6. **No-shows and walkovers.** Does a no-show count as one loss (dropping the player to the losers' side) or as immediate elimination?
7. **Ladies' entries below 33 or above 64** at Circuits 2 and 3 — agree the bracket-size rule now rather than at the draw.

Appendix — what this needs from the platform

For the engineering team. The Circuit stage already exists in the system as a capped, knockout-bracket stage, but this format needs more than the current model expresses.

AREA	TODAY	NEEDED
Bracket model	`knockout_brackets` — one row per stage and category, with rounds hanging off it. No concept of a winners' or losers' side.	A way to express two sides and the crossover between them.
Loser routing	`fixtures` record two participants and a result. Where the *loser* goes next is not modelled — single elimination never needed it.	Each fixture needs a destination for the loser as well as the winner.
Race length	No `race_to` field exists anywhere in the schema.	Race length per round — 6 in Round 1, 5 in Round 2 — so results can be validated against it.
Round ordering	`rounds` carry a name only.	Explicit ordering, so the four Round 1 waves and six Round 2 rounds sequence deterministically.
Byes	`fixtures.walkover_kind` exists for walkovers.	A bye is not a walkover — nobody forfeits. Needs its own representation, plus the draw constraint on page 3.
Draw scope	`draws` requires exactly one of `venue_id` or `region_id`, and `formula_group_count` is mandatory.	A Circuit draw is national and has no groups, so it fits neither slot as the table stands.

Based on the schema as at 2 November 2026. None of this is a blocker for agreeing the format — it is the build list that follows from it.